Rahul was outstanding and his double hundred helped us get close to the Australian first-innings total. Laxman too was majestic and it reminded us of the incredible partnership Rahul and Laxman had put together at Eden Gardens in March 2001, only this time the roles were reversed, with Rahul getting a double hundred and Laxman a hundred. I lasted just six balls before I was caught by Gilchrist off the fast bowler Andy Bichel. It was an annoyingly soft dismissal.

The Australian second innings belonged to Ajit Agarkar, my team-mate from Mumbai. He produced his best ever spell to set up the match for us. He took six Australian wickets for just 41 runs as we bowled the Australians out for 196, leaving us with 230 to chase. We fielded brilliantly in this innings and took some amazing catches, Aakash Chopra's catch of Ponting at point off Ajit being the stand-out. I chipped in with two crucial wickets, bowling leg-spin. Steve Waugh and Damien Martyn had put together a good partnership and it was immensely satisfying to be able to get both of them out caught in the slips. It was time for the batsmen to close out the game.

Rahul was yet again the star performer and I managed to contribute 37 before falling lbw to leg-spinner Stuart MacGill. We had put together a 70-run partnership at a critical time in the match, which was particularly satisfying. Rahul hit the winning runs for us, remaining unbeaten on 72, and the team was thrilled to have taken a 1–0 lead in the series. We stayed in the dressing room till late and thoroughly savoured the moment. Never in our history had we managed a 1–0 lead against Australia in Australia. We had matched the Australians in every aspect of the game and had a very good chance of winning the series if we continued to play at our best. Rahul and Laxman were in imperious form; Sehwag and Sourav had made important contributions in both Tests; Aakash Chopra, our second opener, had done a good job of blunting the new ball.

On the eve of the next game – the Boxing Day Test in Melbourne – I decided to take Anjali, Sara and Arjun out onto the ground, just to give them a feel of what it is like to be inside a stadium. Standing in the middle of the MCG, they could imagine for themselves what we go through with more than 80,000 people in the stands. It was Arjun's first visit to a stadium.

We batted first after winning the toss on 26 December and Virender Sehwag played what must be one of the best Test innings ever seen at the